

The Long Way Home

A SHORT STORY

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The Letter

The letter arrived on a Tuesday, damp at one corner and addressed in a hand she had not seen in twelve years. She read it twice, then set it on the kitchen table and looked at it for a long time, as if it might explain itself.

The Road

The bus left at dawn. She watched the town shrink in the window and tried to remember the last thing he had said to her. The fields gave way to hills, and the hills to a sky that looked the way memory feels: close, and slightly wrong.

The House

The house was smaller than she remembered, but the door was the same green, and it opened before she knocked. For a moment neither of them spoke, and then they both laughed, the way people do when the thing they were afraid of turns out to be ordinary.

The Return

She took the late bus back, the letter folded in her pocket. Nothing had been solved, exactly, but something had been returned to its place. Some roads, she thought, you take not to arrive but to be able to go home.